As of the writing of this essay, I have completed exactly two General Education courses at Iowa State, those courses being LDST 322: Leadership in a Diverse Society, and Honors 321: Understanding War Beyond the Headlines. These courses allowed me to understand the social environment inside and outside of the United States to a deeper level.

LDST 322: Leadership in a Diverse Society is a course that focuses primarily on the intersectionality of identities in the United States. That is, how our social and economic minorities as individuals affect the choices that we make, and the positions that we hold. For example, I am a straight white man from a middle class family. Throughout my time at Iowa State I have been a TA for a course, because I enjoy the work, not because I need the work to pay for attending the school. This allows me to spend more time focusing on school and my clubs, instead of working a job that is unrelated to my major, so my identities that I hold allow me to do better in school. Another point that was iterated many times in the course was that we, as leaders, cannot just enter a new place and tell a group what they need to do to "fix" their problems. We need to empathize with the individuals, which is similar learning objectives in senior design. We, as designers of systems, have to work with our users to meet their needs and to build goals for how humans interact with computational systems, because if we just assume what every user wants, we may design useless systems, or systems that discriminate against people with disabilities.

HON 321: Understanding War Beyond the Headlines was an honors seminar that was offered in Fall of 2024 with a combination of professors from the Journalism, Political Science, World Languages and Cultures, and History departments, where we as students studies the bias in reporting around conflicts in the world. Specifically, we focuses on the Russia/Ukraine conflict, and the Israel/Palestine conflict. Throughout the course, we analyzed the history of the regions and the past conflicts & headlines around those regions in and out of war. This course was really interesting to take as a student outside of the departments that ran it, because it let me extend skills that I hadn't used since high school, and it reminded me of the bias that is in every article, even research articles. When I am reading reports from my peers, they are likely to have a bias towards the solutions that they picked, and so I should try to ensure that they are making good, ethical engineering decisions in their designs.

Overall, general education courses help us understand the world around us, and force students to explore ideas that are not always present in their major, and I have thoroughly enjoyed the courses I have taken so far. I am excited to take a course on Greek and Roman tragedie and comedie next semester to wrap up my required general education courses.